Conclusion

Outlook for a Future Power

‘THE RISE OF India’ is the subject of considerable discussion both among Indians and the international community. India’s size and significance have positioned it to be a major world power but so far it lacks the wherewithal, military capacity and institutional structure to act as one. The British Raj trained Indian civil servants as writers of first drafts, not as policymakers. After Independence, these bureaucrats have jealously guarded their positions at the expense of India’s coming into its own. India’s political leaders have invoked history, more precisely historical imagery, to forge national unity and create an aspiration for India’s place under the sun. The country now needs a pragmatic strategic outlook coupled with forward-looking institutions that can make India into a contemporary version of Chanakya’s Chakravartin.

In the years immediately after Independence, India’s priority was ensuring its territorial integrity and unity, carving out strategic space for India in the global order and securing a South Asia free from foreign influence. Underlying India’s engagement with the world was the belief that India was a great civilization and a future great power. Emerging from colonial rule, wherein all key decisions about its fate were made by foreigners, India wanted autonomy in decision making and economic self-